

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Philemon

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This short letter is the shortest and most personal of Paul's letters. It shows how Christ changes people's attitudes and relationships. Paul wrote it on behalf of Onesimus, a slave who had run away and was returning to his master, Philemon. Paul urged Philemon to do more than follow the usual master-slave relationship. He asked him to welcome Onesimus back as a dear brother in Christ. Through this message of reconciliation (restored relationship), Paul reminds us that Christ's love changes all relationships among Christians, no matter a person's social position.

Setting

Onesimus was an enslaved person who seems to have run away from his Christian master, Philemon. Philemon lived in Colossae, a small town in the Roman province of Asia (now western Turkey). Colossae was about 193 kilometers (120 miles) east of Ephesus. When Onesimus ran away, he might have stolen some of his master's belongings. Somehow, Onesimus met Paul, who was in prison, and became a Christian through Paul's teachings. When Paul learned that Onesimus was a slave who had run away, he encouraged him to return to his master.

Slavery was common in the Roman world. By law, anyone who captured slaves who had run away must return them to their owners. These slaves who ran away often encountered severe punishment. Upon return, they might whip, brand, or execute the slaves to set an example for others.

However, Philemon was a well-respected Christian leader and a gracious, loving person. Paul wrote this letter to Philemon from prison and sent it with Onesimus to ensure a warm Christian welcome for the runaway on what might have been a rather fearful return to his master. The letter resembles a letter of recommendation and carries the full weight of Paul's authority as an apostle (a messenger sent by Jesus).

We do not know what happened when Onesimus returned. However, 50 or 60 years later, in a letter written to the Christians at Ephesus by the Christian martyr Ignatius, the name Onesimus appears again. This time it refers to a highly respected bishop in the province of Asia.

We cannot be sure that this was the same person, but it is possible. Because of his close connection with Paul, Onesimus may have become an important

leader in the church and later served as bishop of the province of Asia. Paul's letter reminds us that social status does not determine a person's value in the church of Jesus Christ.

Summary

Paul encourages Philemon to treat Onesimus no longer as a slave but as a true brother in Christ. In his usual greeting (1:1-3), Paul introduces himself, greets Philemon, his family, and the church that meets in their home, and prays that they will receive grace and peace from God. Paul then thanks God for Philemon, especially for his faith in the Lord Jesus and the love he has shown to God's people (1:4-7).

Paul then makes his appeal for Onesimus (1:8-22). Although Onesimus had run away, he had now become a believer in Christ and had shown that his life had changed. Paul asks Philemon to welcome him back with grace and forgiveness. Paul would prefer Onesimus to remain with him and help him while he is in prison. However, Paul does not use his authority as an apostle to demand this. Instead, he wants any act of kindness to come willingly from Philemon and not because he feels forced. At the same time, Paul clearly suggests that Philemon should consider freeing Onesimus so that he can help spread the good news about Jesus.

The letter ends in the usual way (1:23-25). Paul sends greetings from several fellow believers and prays that the grace of Christ will be with Philemon and those in his household.

Occasion for Writing

Although the traditional view is that Onesimus was a runaway slave, other explanations have been suggested. For example, Onesimus may have been sent to Paul as a messenger. Or he may have asked Paul to help resolve a problem between him and his master. We do not know why Onesimus left Philemon's home. However, the traditional view fits the details of the letter well.

Date and Place of Writing

Traditionally, scholars believe that Paul wrote the Prison Letters (Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, and Philemon) while he was in prison in Rome, around AD 60-62 or AD 64-65. However, some scholars believe that he wrote these letters earlier, during an imprisonment in Ephesus. See Ephesians Book Introduction, "Date and Place of Writing."

Meaning and Message

This letter clearly shows how Christ changes people's attitudes and relationships. Those who know Christ are called to see others with love and to show that love in the way they treat them.

Paul's appeal to Philemon reminds believers that they should always be willing to forgive one another. No matter how others have wronged them, they should be ready to welcome them with kindness and show them acceptance and love.

In the church of Christ, traditional social divisions, such as the relationship between slave and master, should no longer separate people. Christians are called to show genuine love to one another, regardless of their social position, culture, education, ethnic background, or gender (see Galatians 3:28; Colossians 3:11). Paul's desire to bring Philemon and Onesimus back together in peace is an example of this kind of love.

Many people have asked why Paul did not clearly call for Onesimus to be set free or for slavery to end. In the Roman world, slavery was common and played a central role in Roman society. Paul, like many early Christians, appears to have accepted the social structures of his time, including slavery.

The main mission of the early Christians was not to change society through political action. Instead, they focused on helping people come to faith in Christ and grow as his followers. As the good news of salvation spread, Christ changed people's lives and relationships within the church.

Although Paul did not clearly ask Philemon to free Onesimus, he strongly suggests that he would like Onesimus to be released for the work of the good news. Paul consistently taught that Christians should live together in forgiveness and mutual love. These teachings helped shape Christian attitudes toward human relationships and later influenced many efforts to end slavery as an institution.